

SMF VRLA BATTERIES IN DEMAND

Solar and telecom equipment require standby battery systems, driving the demand for SMF VRLA batteries. The inverter market too is shifting towards SMF batteries, owing to their less pollution



Amptek batteries

■ UMA BANSAL

The battery industry in India is growing fast, clocking annual growth rate of 25 per cent for the past four years. This trend is expected to continue in the future as well with the government's focus on infrastructure development, growth in the telecom sector and focus on renewable energy in the current budget.

Talking of the size, the battery market in India is worth around Rs 100 billion with the organised sector contributing about 65 per cent of the total market. The share of sealed maintenance-free valve-regulated lead-acid (SMF VRLA) batteries is 20 to 22 per cent. SMF/VRLA batteries are manufactured by the organised sector and find applications both in automotive as well as non-automotive sectors across industrial, business and office, and home applications.

The customers' expectations are rising day by day. They are looking for off-track unexplored technologies in

India that are quite popular overseas. The trend is to install batteries requiring minimal maintenance as the reliability of electronics improves. The switchover to SMF VRLA batteries is increasing as the price difference narrows for the same capacity of SMF versus other alternatives requiring maintenance.

Demand exceeds supply

Solar and telecom equipment require standby battery systems, driving the demand for SMF VRLA batteries.

"The inverter market too is shifting towards SMF batteries, owing to their

less pollution. We keep inverters in living rooms, which is quite dangerous. When we charge batteries in our homes, lead fumes can be fatal for our body parts like brain and kidney," says Kunwer Sachdev, managing director of Su-Kam Power Systems.

Amitansu Satpathi, director, Best Power Equipment, says, "There is shortage of supply, as the production base in India is quite small." However, the growth in demand is resulting in scaling up of the existing facilities and building of new facilities to minimise the gap between demand and supply.

The plates of SMF batteries are made of lead-calcium, which offers long life and high efficiency due to low self-discharge

—Kapil Sood, managing director, Amptek

